OPEN LETTER · EYE ON SHOALHAVEN COUNCIL

Steve Prothero asks Council for the business case behind its Business Awards sponsorship

Sent 9 July 2026 · To Mayor White, Shoalhaven City Council · Response requested by 22 July 2026

8 July 2026

Mayor Patricia White

Shoalhaven City Council

By email: mayor@shoalhaven.nsw.gov.au
cc: Andrew Constance, Chief Executive Officer — andrew.constance@shoalhaven.nsw.gov.au (approving officer under Council's Sponsorship Policy, POL22/209)

Dear Mayor White,

I write in the knowledge that correspondence from this publication has, in recent months, been declined on the basis of guidance relating to unreasonable conduct. I note, for the record, that the application of that guidance to a public interest publication with more than 3,800 local readers is itself a matter currently before the NSW Ombudsman. The questions in this letter are not personal complaints. They are questions of public administration, put openly, on behalf of a readership that represents approximately 5.1 per cent of Shoalhaven's registered voters. They are questions any member of the public could put at an ordinary council meeting. I put them here, in writing, on the public record — and will publish whatever response is received, including none.

Shoalhaven City Council is listed as a Major Sponsor of the Shoalhaven Business Awards, the Shoalhaven Business Chamber's annual black-tie gala at the Entertainment Centre. Council's own Sponsorship Policy (POL22/209) requires any sponsorship valued at $2,000 or more to be approved in writing by the CEO and disclosed in the Annual Report. It also requires, before that approval, an assessment of the "benefit/cost to Council" and the "proportion of sponsorship dollars to overall costs."

I have been unable to find that assessment, that dollar figure, or that disclosure anywhere in the public record — not on Council's website, not in recent Annual Reports, and not in anything the Business Chamber has published. I am asking you directly, on the record, for the following:

1. What is the total value — cash and in-kind — of Council's sponsorship of the Shoalhaven Business Awards for the current and most recent financial year?

1. What written business case or benefit/cost assessment was prepared before that sponsorship was approved, as required under Council's own Sponsorship Policy?

1. What measurable, quantified benefit to ratepayers — as distinct from general assertions that the sponsorship "fosters a thriving business environment" — has Council documented from this sponsorship, this year or in any previous year?

1. In which Annual Report has this sponsorship been disclosed, in accordance with Council's own Sponsorship Policy, and at what dollar value?

1. Why is this sponsorship funded from general ratepayer revenue rather than a model — such as the NSW Government's new Community Improvement District framework — under which the businesses that benefit from the event fund it themselves?

1. Council reduced its family day care service in 2025 to save approximately $90,000, describing that cost as unsustainable. What comparable value-for-money test was applied to this sponsorship, and why did it produce a different outcome?

These are not hostile questions. Ratepayers are entitled to know what they are buying when Council's name and money appear on a sponsor board at a private industry association's awards night. If the sponsorship delivers real, measurable value, the business case should already exist and should be simple to produce. If it doesn't exist, ratepayers are entitled to know that too.

I would appreciate a substantive response by 22 July 2026. As set out above, I will publish this letter and whatever response — or non-response — it receives.

Yours sincerely,

Steve Prothero

Eye on Shoalhaven Council

Note to councillors receiving a copy of this letter: The questions above are put to the Mayor and CEO on the public record. If you believe they warrant answers, you are in a position to raise them directly in the chamber — through a Question on Notice, a Notice of Motion, or a question to the Mayor in open council. That is one of the most effective ways to place these matters on the public record in a forum where a response cannot be declined. This publication will report whatever is raised and whatever is answered.